HONG KONG–SHENZHEN / AN EXPLORATORY STUDY

# CROSS-BORDER LIVES

## Everyday opportunities, adjustments and connections

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AsiaGlobal Fellows · 2 November 2026




At JB Sentral

Research and presentation: Jamie Ko / Visual support: Bob / Field photographs supplied by Bob and Jamie

Hong Kong-centred exploratory study. People in field photographs are not identified as interviewees.

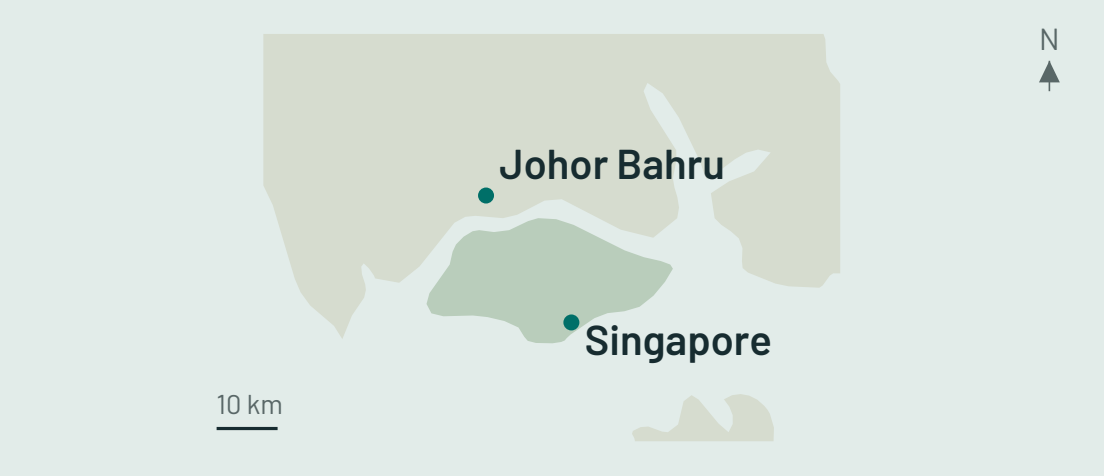
REGIONAL CONTEXT

# Two city pairs; different institutional settings.




## Hong Kong–Shenzhen

One country; different systems




## Singapore–Johor

JS-SEZ in Johor / RTS is a separate rail link

MTI / EDB, JS-SEZ factsheet [1]; LTA / Malaysia MOT [2]; Natural Earth locator geometry

Selected places, not zone or route boundaries. RTS passenger-service target: February 2027, subject to approvals.

THE STUDY QUESTION

# What do everyday experiences reveal about integration?

## What opportunities and adjustments do people encounter?

## How do they make cross-border arrangements work?

Hong Kong-centred exploratory inquiry / selected experiences and published evidence [7–8]

The comparison informs questions for Singapore–Johor; it does not predict the same changes there.

EXISTING RESEARCH AND THIS STUDY

# Research describes systems, purchases and patterns of daily activity.

Integration creates opportunities; benefits and adjustment pressures differ. [16]

## Systems

Economic, institutional and social integration move at different speeds.

Shen · 2014 publication

## Purchases

Different spending mixes across Hong Kong and Mainland China.

Gao, Han & Song · 2025 / data mainly to 2024

## Activity patterns

Home, work and other activities cluster differently.

Xiao, Cai & Zhang · 2026 / 2023 data

THIS STUDY ADDS PEOPLE'S ACCOUNTS

**Reasons for crossing · choices combined · relationships maintained**

Shen (2014) [3]; Gao, Han & Song (2025) [4]; Xiao, Cai & Zhang (2026) [5]; WTO (2024) [16]

Different periods, geographies and methods. General economic context is not an estimate for either city pair.

THE GROUNDWORK

# Conversations and visits, read alongside published evidence.

**14+**

## Individual and group conversations

Plus brief exchanges during visits

**3**

## Shenzhen trips

Futian rail · Lo Wu rail · AGF coach

**Studies · statistics · programme documents**

Used to compare with the accounts

**Hong Kong–Shenzhen Innovation and Technology Park visit**

**Sheung Shui walk and local chats**

Qualitative fieldwork and source records [7–8]

At least 14 conversation occasions, not 14 unique people. Illustrative experiences, not a representative sample.

AN ADAPTED WAY TO READ THE MATERIAL

# Three lenses for the accounts

A

## Livelihoods and choices

Household choices and local business conditions

B

## Everyday services and navigation

Services offered around lives spanning both places

C

## Relationships and support

Connections that continue and opportunities that develop

Institutions run across all three.

Selected themes adapted from Arup / Resilient Cities Network, City Resilience Framework (2024) [6]

Study lenses, not official framework dimensions or a measured city resilience score.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS / 1–2

# Users and movers

## 01 CROSS-BORDER USER





### Repair customer

### Dining visitors

Based mainly on one side; selected activities across the border

## 02 NORTHBOUND MOVER



### Guide who moved north

Home moves from Hong Kong to Shenzhen

Illustrative accounts [7] / conceptual role illustrations, not interviewee portraits

Arrangements describe behaviour and can overlap. Names are recurring labels; all accounts are paraphrased.

FOUR OVERLAPPING ARRANGEMENTS / 3–4

# Work, study and continuing ties

## 03 CROSS-BORDER WORKER / STUDENT



### Schooling illustration

**16,139**

Daily cross-boundary schoolchildren

2024/25 · official evidence

## 04 HONG KONG BASE / MAINLAND TIES



### Resident with Shenzhen ties

Works & rents in HK

Property, family & friends in Shenzhen

Resident's account [7]; Education Bureau, 2026/27 Estimates, annex table 1 [9]

Schoolchild is a research illustration, not an interviewee. Mainland homes are not necessarily in Shenzhen.

LOCALLY BASED ACCOUNTS / SHEUNG SHUI

# The people who remain locally based



## Sheung Shui store manager

Fanling home · Sheung Shui work



## Sheung Shui resident

Resident near the border



## Sheung Shui shop employee

Employee at an estate shop

Three brief Sheung Shui chats and walking observations, 31 October 2026 [8]

Distinct accounts, not a local population sample. Crossing for an activity does not mean moving home or all spending.

LENS A / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES

# Shenzhen attracts some activities; Hong Kong routines remain.

## REASONS TO CHOOSE SHENZHEN



Repair customer

### Parts & expertise

For older equipment



Dining visitors

### Choice · space · price

Online options when local shops lack stock



Guide who moved north

### Preferred work, lower living costs

Lower earnings too; prepared before moving

## REASONS SOME ACTIVITIES STAY LOCAL



Sheung Shui store manager

### Meals in SZ; shopping mainly in HK

Visits about monthly



Sheung Shui resident

### Crowding limits crossings

Infrequent visits

PARENT'S PERSONAL ACCOUNT · PARAPHRASED

Child's HK activities leave little time; with childcare + half a day, might visit.

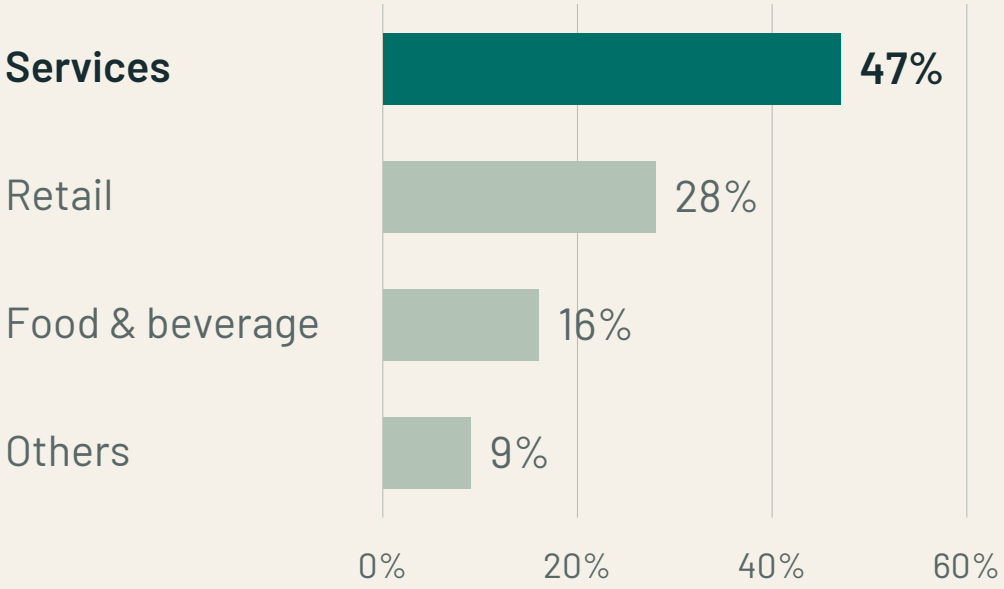
Repair customer, dining visitors, guide, parent [7]; Sheung Shui store manager and resident [8]

Selected accounts, not fixed household categories. No quotations or measured savings; illustrations identify roles.

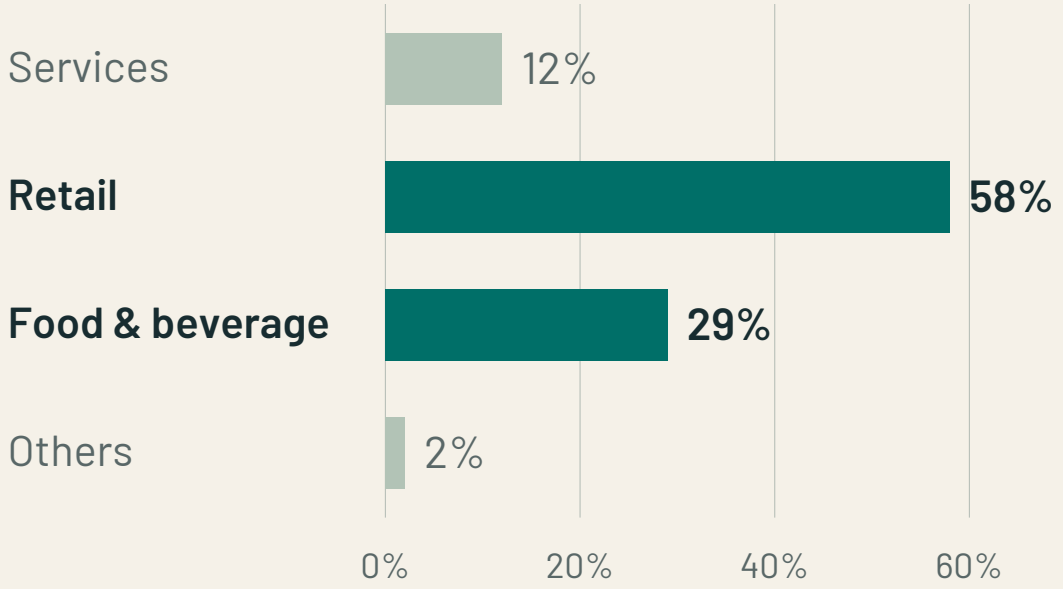
LENS A / HOUSEHOLD CHOICES · PUBLISHED EVIDENCE

# Mainland: services. Hong Kong: retail and dining.

## MAINLAND CHINA




## HONG KONG




Share of recorded spending within each location · seasoned AlipayHK users

CUHK research release, Figure 3 · 19 June 2025 [4]

Within-location spending shares; HK totals 101% after rounding. Mainland is broader than Shenzhen. Not displaced local spending.

LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS

# Business exposure differs by customers and occasions.



Guide who moved north

## Meal occasion matters

Daily meals near work

vs special-occasion dining



Sheung Shui shop employee

## Nearby residents

Estate shop

Few tourists described



Sheung Shui store manager

## Locals + Mainland visitors

Landmark North

Busier Monday–Thursday



## Fewer crowds, in two accounts

Resident + estate-shop employee

Comparable footfall data still needed

## Do chains adapt better?

Familiar chains observed; a question to test, not a survival finding.

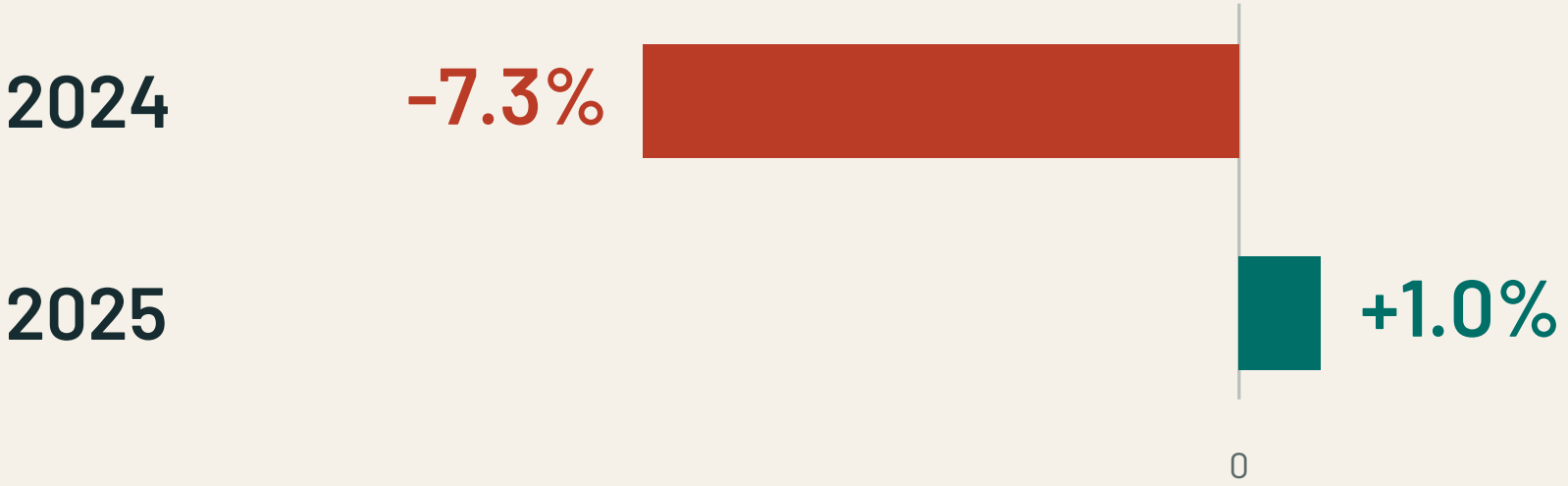
Guide's interpretation [7]; Sheung Shui staff/resident accounts and walking observations [8]

Reported customer mixes and perceptions, not measured market shares, restaurant impacts or business survival.

LENS A / LOCAL BUSINESS CONDITIONS · CITYWIDE CONTEXT

# Retail-sales value fell in 2024, then rose modestly in 2025.

ANNUAL CHANGE IN HONG KONG RETAIL-SALES VALUE




Wider context; it does not establish what caused local changes.

Census and Statistics Department, annual retail-sales value [10]

Value, not volume. Citywide changes do not isolate Shenzhen's effect or establish a Sheung Shui footfall trend.

LENS A / TAKEAWAY

# Cross-border choices are selective; business pressures vary.

## Availability and price

Shenzhen offers alternatives for selected experiences and services.

## Daily routines

Time and convenience keep some spending in Hong Kong.

## Customers and occasions

Competition differs by whom a business serves and when.

Integration can help people combine what each place offers.

Exploratory synthesis of selected accounts, consumption research and retail context [4, 7–8, 10]

No net welfare calculation, representative household gain or causal business-loss estimate.

LENS B / EVERYDAY SERVICES AND NAVIGATION

# Services help people manage activities in both places.

FUTIAN ARRIVAL Immigration staff helped with the arrival form.

## Information & referrals




Separate help point at Futian

## Cross-border delivery




Visible storefronts in Shenzhen

## Licence conversion




Assistance advertised in Sheung Shui

PROPERTY AGENT'S ACCOUNT · PARAPHRASED

Tuition in Shenzhen for Hong Kong-curriculum students.

Futian observation and property-agent account [7]; Sheung Shui visit [8]; photographs supplied by Bob and Jamie

Observed provision and reported offerings are distinct. Licence conversion, not vehicle plates. Use and outcomes not assessed.

LENS B / A DOCUMENTED HEALTHCARE ARRANGEMENT

# Follow-up care in Shenzhen, with a route back to Hong Kong.

HKU–SHENZHEN HOSPITAL FOLLOW-UP PILOT

**>5,900**

**Eligible HA patients joined**

By January 2026

**HA follow-up appointment** → **Corresponding clinic in Shenzhen**

Patients authorise access to records through eHealth.

**Return to HA follow-up** ← Referral on request, according to clinical need

HKSAR Government replies [12]; Health Bureau, 31 March 2026: eligibility, records and return referrals

Defined outpatient follow-up eligibility. January participation date follows the script; enrolment does not establish clinical outcomes.

LENS B / TAKEAWAY

# Cross-border needs can also create business activity.

**Services around cross-border lives**

Delivery · tuition · paperwork assistance

→

**Potential income and employment**

Alongside public and community support where commercial provision does not meet needs.

Synthesis of observed and reported services [7–8]; documented healthcare arrangement [12]

Scale and wider economic contribution remain unmeasured. No SEZ causality or GDP estimate.

LENS C / CONTINUING CONNECTIONS

# Work, housing and relationships need not be in one city.

## HONG KONG

### Work & rented home



Resident with Shenzhen ties

## SHENZHEN

### Property, family & friends

Many activities; a sense of home

### Family visits



Guide who moved north

### Home, community & guiding friends

Friends brought a lead to qualify for preferred work.

Resident with Shenzhen ties and guide who moved north: accounts [7]

Connections, not measured commutes. Property is one resident's explanation of home. Illustrations identify roles.

LENS C / NEW CONNECTIONS

# Work and interests offer ways into new circles.

## SHENZHEN



**Guiding friendships**

**Sports & interests**

**Food-related activities**

Guide who moved north

## HONG KONG



**Sports & coaching**

**Volunteering**

**Animal activities · beach cleaning**

Dining visitors

Mandarin helped her join in, in her view.

Guide and dining visitors: reported community examples [7]

Dining visitors described Hong Kong activities during a Shenzhen outing. No programme-effect or population inference.

LENS C / TAKEAWAY

# Residence alone does not show where people connect and participate.

**Existing ties** Keep visits and activities connected to one city.

**New contacts** Help people enter opportunities in another.

Exploratory synthesis of the resident's, guide's and dining visitors' accounts [7]

Qualitative insight, not a population measure of belonging, support or participation.

A QUESTION RAISED BY THE THREE LENSES

# Can lasting ties sustain participation after a move or change in routine?

A HYPOTHESIS TO INVESTIGATE

Residence, relationships and a sense of home may change in different ways.

**Continued spending**

**Useful referrals**

**Community participation**

Track these separately from where someone lives.

A wider research question arising from the accounts [7]

Stronger ties sustaining participation is a hypothesis, not an effect measured in this study.

QUESTIONS WORTH EXPLORING

# Questions for further inquiry

## A LIVELIHOODS AND CHOICES

### Which businesses can adapt—and which workers need help?

- Online competition and market reach
- Workers' next jobs and earnings

## B EVERYDAY SERVICES

### Which needs can support viable businesses?

- Demand, use and costs
- Where public or community support is needed

## C RELATIONSHIPS AND SUPPORT

### Do lasting ties sustain participation after a move?

- Spending, referrals and contribution
- Connections that can continue remotely

Further inquiry prompted by selected accounts and contextual evidence

Research questions, not findings. Measurement details and potential responses remain in the supporting appendices.

SINGAPORE–JOHOR / QUESTIONS TO EXAMINE LOCALLY

# Which purchases move, and which ties remain?

Different countries, work/residence rules and service arrangements

## For businesses

FORECAST ADDITIONAL ANNUAL SPENDING WITH RTS

SG consumers to JB



**S$1.05bn**

JB consumers to SG



**S$756m**

About S$290m net incremental outflow

**Ask customers what they would buy or do in JB, and why.**

Proposal: HK–SZ learning exchange, then small local tests

## For lives across the border

IF TRAVEL BECAME EASIER

**Around 1 in 3**

Singapore respondents could envisage buying a JB home and retiring there.

Conditional interest · 2024 survey

**Continued spending, relationships and participation?**

Remote ties · new needs for Johor providers

**Johor residents: how do changing demand, jobs, housing and services affect them?**

RTS study commissioned by SBF / RAS / SRA, July 2026 [13]; Blackbox SensingSG, February 2024 [14]

Hatched bars = forecasts, not GDP or JS-SEZ effects. Survey interest is not migration. Exchange is a proposal.

WHAT THESE ACCOUNTS HELP US SEE

# Everyday choices reveal opportunities and adjustments.

**A** Shenzhen alternatives create competition; HK routines still anchor spending.

**B** Cross-border needs create service opportunities, alongside public and community support.

**C** Relationships sustain connections and open opportunities across cities.

THE WIDER QUESTION

## How do lasting ties relate to participation and belonging when life spans cities?

Sources, field photographs and interactive research